like Bengali auteur Buddhadeb Dasgupta and crowd-pleasing documentaries like *Smile Pinki* and *Supermen of Malegaon*.

Making Waves: A New Generation of Indian Independent Filmmakers, curated by La Frances Hui, is the largest Indian festival at MoMA since 2009 and returns to MoMA's core mission: highlighting recent developments in cinema. Intended to showcase "small-budget but artistically ambitious and accomplished films" that "have expanded the making of, thinking about, and ways of seeing Indian film" since 2010, *Making Waves* includes 16 features and five shorts in languages as diverse as Assamese, Bengali, Dogri, Hindi, Maithili, Marathi, Malayalam and Tamil.



While staying away from mainstream commercial work, the films at MoMA cut a wide swathe in terms of cinematic style and degree of political charge. Aditya Vikram Sengupta's ambitiously wordless 2014 debut *Labour of Love* uses visual and sound design to suggest that love in the late-capitalist Indian city is a hard-won (perhaps unfindable) reprieve from the repetitiveness of labour. Pushpendra Singh adapts the folktales of Vijaydan Detha into dreamy, evocative, allegorical visions, featuring contrary female protagonists from marginalised nomadic communities. His 2014 *The Honour Keeper* follows Mani Kaul's 1973 *Duvidha*, drawing on the same Detha telling of a ghost filling in for a harsh, unromantic or absent husband and staying within the same Rajasthani visual palette of rich reds, sparkling whites and empty brown desert sands. Meanwhile, his *The Shepherdess and the Seven Songs* (2020) transports another Detha story to Jammu and Kashmir—and thus to a frightening contemporary context involving Indian policemen and the migrant Muslim shepherd community of the Bakerwals. *Shepherdess* adopts a semi-comic distance from the power dynamics it deals with, producing some kinship with Chaitanya Tamhane's brilliant debut *Court* (2014), in which a fatal manual scavenging accident is blamed first on its victim and then on a Dalit singer who may have sung against manual scavenging.

Making Waves includes 16 features and five shorts in a variety of languages

Films like Amit Dutta's *Nainsukh* or Ashim Ahluwalia's short *Events in a Cloud Chamber* offer philosophical engagements with the history of Indian visual art. Others are rooted in the country's visual and aural history while tracking the tectonic shifts in the Indian sociopolitical landscape. The passing of an older way of life becomes the subject of Achal Mishra's *Gamak Ghar*, a moving visual essay on an old rural home with increasingly urban owners.

There is little redemption in the present, where everyday occurrences reveal the darkest aspects of the Indian psyche: Sanal Sasidharan's disturbing *An Off-Day Game* is about a meeting of Malayali drinking buddies, while a teenage outing turns tragic in Rima Das's *Bulbul Can Sing*. In Sasidharan's *Sexy Durga*, one couple's experience on the road unmasks Indian men as the monsters they are, while a gentle day in the life of a sari shop salesman unfolds as less than gentle in Arun Karthick's Coimbatore-set *Nasir*. Payal Kapadia's *A Night of Knowing Nothing* takes us through the past eight years through an Indian college student's eyes, capturing the tumult and horror of the state's multipronged attack on universities—repression, censorship, violence and privatisation. Watching these films together is an education in New India. ■

–Trisha Gupta



***Testimony of Ana* tells the story of Anaben Pawar, a tribal woman from Dang, Gujarat**

feature of *Testimony of Ana* is that it forsakes the commonly used talking-heads format, prevalent in documentaries, for a she-said narrative device. For Dheeraj, this became the obvious choice after Pawar narrated what she had endured, little by little. He didn't follow Dangi, Pawar's language of communication, but the "strength and conviction", "the anger" said it all.

Dheeraj excels in how he juxtaposes the horror of Pawar's ordeal against the sylvan backdrop of the village—the rain, the mist, the fallen trees, the river. That tribals like Pawar are connected to nature and their worship of it only makes the film more poignant. "The image is an illusion, it's the voice that hits you hard. We really wanted her [Anaben] to dictate the rhythm of the film," says Dheeraj.

Currently an assistant professor teaching film production at Sam Houston State University, Dheeraj aims to shuttle between making films and teaching filmmaking. "I want to tell stories of ordinary people who are ignored or people we are not aware of." Dheeraj produces films with his wife, Janani Vijayanathan, under their banner, Kinostreet. His next release will be his thesis film titled *Men in Blue*, a fictional tale inspired by the plight of Indians trafficked into the United States in 2007 and ultimately exploited. For now, though, Dheeraj is busy spreading the word about *Testimony of Ana*. The goal is that it gets nominated for Best Documentary Short. If it does so, it will only be the third Indian film to get an Oscar nod. ■

–Suhani Singh